Arooj Aftab isn't one to be awed by occasion. When invited by the White House to celebrate Eid ul-Fitr earlier this month, the singer had little idea she would be sharing the presidential podium with Joe and Jill Biden. Speaking to INDIA TODAY last week, she said her experience reminded her of the political satire series *Veep*. "It is exactly like that—the interactions, protocol, comedy, the dynamics. It is serious and also normal. I read a poem by Rumi. It was full-on. It was fun. It was also really crazy."

This wasn't the first time Aftab had been on the radar of an American president. Barack Obama's 2021 summer playlist had included 'Mohabbat', arguably the most popular track from *Vulture Prince*, an album Aftab released last year. Written by Hafeez Hoshiarpuri, 'Mohabbat Karne Wale' wasn't new—it was famously part of Mehdi Hasan's and Fareeda Khanum's ghazal repertoire—but Aftab's rendition was strikingly novel. Rather than drawing attention to the words, it signalled to their mood. This interpretation was capacious, giving room to its few instruments—the guitar, harp and flugelhorn.

As the first Pakistani woman to be nominated for a Grammy, Aftab doubled her chances by making it to two shortlists—*Vulture Prince* put her on the list of Best New Artist nominees, while 'Mohabbat' put her in the running for Best Global Music Performance. It was, finally, 'Mohabbat' that saw her make history last month. "I don't even have the Grammy. They haven't mailed it yet," laughs Aftab. Though her humour is infectious, the 37-year-old, one sees, isn't wholly oblivious to the significance of this moment. "It's an extremely important accolade to collect. It's almost annoyingly exclusive—they do not give it to you so easily—but it gives you access to more things in a more legitimate way."

Aftab's third album seems to be at odds with her obvious zest. Melancholy seeps through it like an ink stain. Some of the sorrow might be Aftab's own—she lost her brother, Maher, and friend, Annie Ali Khan, while making the album—but much of it, one feels, is the baggage of our own hurt and heartbreak that we bring to music. Aftab calls music her "lifesaver". She says it is something that helps her "calm down and process and build". Given the possibilities of feeling that songs like 'Mohabbat' and 'Inayaat' afford, they can be a "full-on catharsis" for Aftab and us, too. Last year, even singer Elvis Costello went on record to say that *Vulture Prince* had come to his rescue during a spell of grieving.

While Aftab's description of her sound strikes one as too technical—"post-jazz, minimalist, crossover music"—her take on *Vulture Prince* proves more lively: "It's kind of disheartened but nostalgic. Not outwardly sad, but a music that has secrets inside of it. It's a little elusive, not super obvious." Aftab suggests that this tone of the album ties up some-

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